

Shortcut line

DO Use one calm household sentence: "Finished is not the same as learned."

HOW Say it when AI help shows up — without shame.

WHY Separates polish from practice.

Fridge AI sandbox

DO Write which tools and which tasks are allowed. Everything else = ask a person first.

HOW Small card on the fridge. Review monthly together.

WHY Clear boundary without banning all AI.

Try-alone timer

DO Work 15–25 minutes with AI closed before any bot help.

HOW Kitchen timer or phone in another room used only as a timer.

WHY Protects the first struggle that builds understanding.

First-attempt gate

DO Before opening AI, the child writes or says a first try.

HOW Sticky note, draft line, or voice note to a parent.

WHY Stops the "answer first" habit.

Explain-aloud exit

DO After the work, sixty seconds in their own words: What did you do? What was hard?

HOW Parent or sibling listens. No need to grade the speech.

WHY Catches pages that look finished but aren't understood.

Two surfaces

DO Schoolwork on a laptop or tablet; phone elsewhere.

HOW Phone in the arrival basket during homework block.

WHY Cuts feed switching mid-learning.

Process over polish

DO Keep messy steps — draft, scrap paper, photo of work, history of edits.

HOW Folder or shared album: "process." Teachers can ask for it too.

WHY Learning evidence, not only a clean final.

Human help ladder

DO When stuck, follow an order: self → person (parent, sibling, teacher, book) → AI only if the sandbox allows.

HOW Post the ladder next to the sandbox card.

WHY Sequence and honesty — tools second.

Make before generate

DO Sketch, outline, or brainstorm by hand before any text or image generator.

HOW Five to fifteen minutes on paper first. Then tool if allowed.

WHY Own ideas first; less sameness, more voice.

One AI-free creative slot weekly

DO Music, drawing, building, cooking, or writing with no generators.

HOW Same slot each week if you can. Protect it like sport practice.

WHY Creativity grows with use — at home, not only in a prompt box.

Adult models struggle

DO Once a week, a parent does one hard task without AI where the child can see.

HOW Taxes, a recipe from scratch, a work problem, a letter — narrate briefly: "I'm stuck; I'm trying again."

WHY If adults never struggle on the page, children will not either.

Process cues on major tasks

DO Ask for steps shown, draft history, or a short oral defense — not only the final file.

HOW One line in the assignment brief. Same rule across subjects when possible.

WHY Grades thinking, not only output.

Shared classroom phrases

DO Agree three phrases school-wide:
Try alone first. Explain in your own
words. Tools second.

HOW Post them. Use them in
homework notes to families.

WHY Students hear one clear story,
not mixed signals.